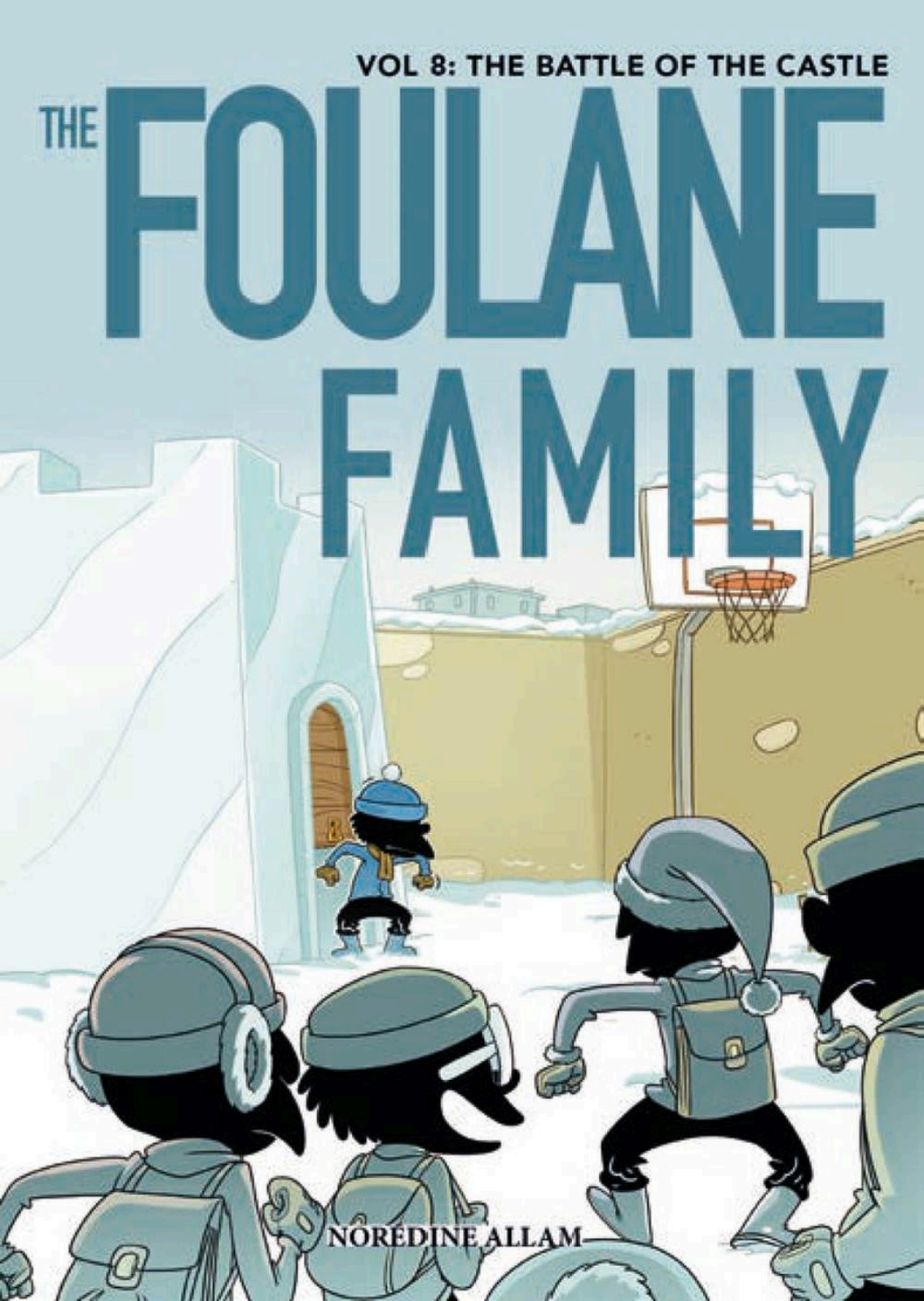
VOL 8: THE BATTLE OF THE CASTLE

THE FOULANE FAMILY



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THE FOULANE FAMILY

Vol 8. The Battle of the Castle

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The Foulane Family

Vol.8

The Battle of the Castle

By Norédine Allam.

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1. The ice block

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The main topic of conversation today among me and my friends was what this huge block of ice – that had appeared overnight in the middle of the playground – was going to be used for.



It was three to four metres high!
“But how did he get here?” Rachid asked.
“Look at the tracks on the ground,” Anass remarked.
“These are caterpillar tracks…” I suggested.

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"Wow! Giant caterpillars?!" Rachid exclaimed.
"I didn't think these insects could be so big."



"Of course they don't..!" commented Jeremy. "He's talking about about the metal tracks that are put on tractors so they can drive on snow."

"Yeah, I think it was a machine with a giant arm that installed it last night," Anass surmised. "Look! You can still see marks on the corners of the cube!"

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Just as we got a little closer to better analyse the block, the headmaster arrived together with a teacher who was carrying a portable sound system and another adult. He was a two-metre tall giant and was carrying a large duffle bag.

After plugging in the microphone and adjusting the levels, which cause some high-pitched shrills which attracted everyone's attention, the headmaster was able to speak.



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"Children, I would like to introduce to you Mr. Gagnon, he's the father of Logan, who you know already."

"Logan? Who's that?" breathed Jeremy.

"Isn't he Max's cousin?" Rachid hesitated.

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"Of course not! He's William's little brother," Anass said.

"Ha... so Mr. Gagnon is William's dad?" Rachid asked.

"Yes, but... No. It's more complicated than that," Anass whispered.

"Anyway, whoever's father he was, we were all



wondering why the headmaster was introducing him to the whole school. And, more important, what's this giant ice cube going to be used for?

"Mr. Gagnon is a well-known artist in his home country of Canada. He makes incredible sculptures out of ice using chainsaw," explained the headmaster. "He has agreed to make one especially for the children of the school. Isn't that great? He he!"

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While the headmaster was talking, Mr. Gagnon opened his bag and pulled out his formidable machine.



"Wow!! A Golgot 3000!" Jeremy exclaimed.

"It looks super dangerous," I retorted.

"For sure, no child should get their hands on that," Jeremy continued. "With its double blades, it could cut a half in half in a matter of seconds. I know this because my uncle has one and made this joke to my dad..!"



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While we were busy discussing chainsaws, Mr. Gagnon spoke at the microphone.

"Dear children. In my hometown of Quebec, it's common for huge ice sculptures to be made every winter."
HAHAHA! All the children in the school laughed when they heard his funny way of speaking.



"Ha ha, are you laughing because of my accent? You can. We also laugh a lot when we hear you speak."

"As I was saying, as Quebec-ers we are used to extreme cold and ice," explained Mr. Gagnon. "And rather than making sculptures out of sand on the beach, we do it out of snow! Ha ha!"

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"This is our first winter here in Foulanville," continued Mr. Gagnon. "So I thought I'd go to Gardenorama and buy a small chainsaw to make something for the school."

And then, with a quick movement, he started up the chainsaw by pulling the starter cord, just like on Abi's lawnmower.

PATATATATATRATRATA!!



Wow! The machine made a tremendous noise!

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“Okay kids, hold onto your hats! Things are going to get crazy! Hahaha!” shouted Mr. Gagnon as he lifted up the buzzing machine.



All the children screamed with joy without really understanding what was going to happen.

The headmaster rammed his fingers into his ears and grimaced. The idea of putting up with this noise all day didn’t thrill him.

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2. Mystery sculpture

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After the headmaster had setup a safety perimeter around the ice block, Mr. Gagnon climbed up it using his special boots and an ice pick, taking care to turn off his chainsaw before ascending.



"Look, there are like sharp crampons on the soles of his shoes," I said, while pointing them out to my friends.

"Yup, those are boots with climbing crampons," clarified Jeremy. "My father used to sell them in his store, but he had to stop after a customer got injured playing football with them on!"

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Arriving at the top of the cube, Mr. Gagnon restarted his chainsaw and began his sculpture. With each stroke of his blade, ice-filled dust gushed in all directions and sprayed the crowd. It was great!

Together with my friends, we had a lot of fun running through it as if it was a cloud.

On the other hand, we had to be careful to keep our mouths closed on each pass, so we didn't swallow melted snow...



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In class, the teacher had a lot of trouble doing his lesson. The sound of the chainsaw echoed throughout the playground and prevented us from hearing it clearly.



Some children, eager to see the final result, pretended to discreetly drop their rubber in the direction of the window, then ask permission to pick it up, and thus, stealthily, glance at the playground. But, with the cloud of ice that surrounded the sculpture, it was impossible to see clearly. As a result, everyone had their own prediction.

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